

EG United Kingdom: Farage's by-election gamble could trash Reform's momentum

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Farage's by-election gamble could trash Reform's momentum

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

* Reform UK leader Nigel Farage should comfortably defeat comedic candidate Count Biface in the 13 August Clacton by-election, but a campaign dominated by ridicule is unlikely to restore his authority or reinvigorate his party's political ascent.

* If Farage loses, he will stay on as party leader and fight to reclaim the seat in the next general election, while a win would bring a resumed parliamentary inquiry into his donations.

* Prolonged scrutiny would damage both Farage and Reform and, combined with the growing challenge from Restore Britain, hurt its chances of capturing more of the right-of-center voters it needs to win a general election.

Farage's plan to mount another political fightback is likely to backfire. The Reform UK leader shocked the political world by resigning as the member of parliament (MP) for Clacton and announcing he would stand in the ensuing by-election. But his narrative that rivals were ganging up on the antiestablishment Reform with allegations about improper donations was scuppered when other parties declined to contest the by-election, dismissing it as a stunt.

With mainstream parties staying away, Farage's main rival is now Biface—the alter ego of comedian Jon Harvey—an “intergalactic space warrior” with a silver cape and dustbin-shaped helmet who comes from the planet Sigma IX and is more than 5,900 years old. His policies include capping the price of a 99 chocolate Flake ice cream cone at 99 pence and giving television presenter Claudia Winkleman's fringe listed building status. Another eight fringe candidates have also entered the contest.

The Reform leader should comfortably see off Biface. Clacton is Reform's safest seat, and Farage won 46% of the vote there in 2024. Biface's best performance in his previous elections was a 1% result.

However, Ipsos found that 33% of people across the country want Binnage to win, and only 21% prefer Farage. Remarkably, some bookmakers are offering five-to-one odds on a Binnage victory, though Farage is the odds-on favorite.

A humiliating upset is unlikely. Turnout will probably be low, and Farage will likely mobilize his supporters. However, Reform sources say Farage has drawn up a contingency plan: if he loses, he will stay on as party leader and fight for the seat at the general election. Even if Farage wins the by-election, with the other parties absent, it could prove a hollow victory.

Although Reform has led polls since April 2025, its average has slipped from 31% to 27%. This is not enough to win an election. Farage's personal ratings are also down. Reform insiders are increasingly worried about the threat to its right flank from Restore Britain, led by former Reform MP Rupert Lowe. Farage hopes the by-election will unite his party amid rising tension between Reform founders and former Conservatives who have defected to the party—symbolized by a public dispute over deportations policy between Zia Yusuf, Reform's home affairs spokesman, and Robert Jenrick, the former Conservative minister who is now Farage's Treasury spokesman.

The paused inquiry into whether Farage broke parliamentary rules will resume if he is reelected. If he is found guilty and the House of Commons approves a suspension of at least ten days, a petition from 10% of Clacton voters could force a recall by-election. The other parties would participate in that contest, hoping that anti-Reform tactical voting might put Farage under pressure. Some 60% of the public think Farage has not behaved correctly on donations, while only 13% believe he has, according to YouGov. The risk is that his populist party looks just as bad as the establishment parties he has long criticized.

The donation scandal and by-election ridicule will hinder Reform's ability to widen its appeal. Farage had hoped to expand his base by attracting right-of-center voters who have not yet been won over by Reform. A vote share of 32%-35% would probably be enough to win a Commons majority. But his recent missteps leave him shoring up Reform's core vote—in effect, preaching to the converted. This is a potential opening for the Conservatives. Voters have noted Tory leader Kemi Badenoch's improved performance in recent months; she now has the highest net favorability rating of any party leader, according to Opinium. But her personal bounce has not lifted the party as a whole; a continuing Farage wobble could change that.

Restore Britain is also a significant thorn in Reform's side—it came third with 7% of the vote in the Makerfield by-election won by Andy Burnham. The party is highly unlikely to make a breakthrough but could deprive Reform of some of its target seats in the next election by siphoning off enough of its voters.

Still, Reform will not fade away and has stronger foundations than Farage's previous parties. Even though it has only seven MPs, its sweeping gains in May's local elections show it will probably be the main challenger to Labour in the next election. As such, the Clacton contest might be something of a joke, but there are potentially serious implications for Farage. It might not provide the renewed momentum he needs and hopes for. For once, Farage might not have the last laugh.

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